Judaism

Quick Facts: Judaism

Name: Judaism.

Founder: Traditional/legendary founders: Abraham and Moses.

Date: There is some debate over how to define "Judaism" and whether to distinguish it from the more ancient religion of the Hebrews. If separate, Judaism's origin is in the 500s–400s BCE. Rabbinic Judaism begins in the first or second century CE.

God: Monotheistic, though earlier views recognized other gods but prohibited their worship. Many Jews will not pronounce or write the name of God (YHWH).

Calendar: Year 1 = 3761 BCE. Lunar, with seven months added over every nineteen-year period to keep the seasons in line with the solar year.

Location: Started in Middle East, with Palestine being the main land of habitation. Because of migration and exile, the Jewish Diaspora spread widely across Mesopotamian and Mediterranean areas. Major centers now are in North America and Israel.

Primary Texts: Tanakh (consisting of Torah, Prophets, and Writings). The Mishnah and Talmud have been definitive texts for almost all Jewish groups during the Common Era and still hold authoritative status with the Orthodox.

Main Concepts: The Hebrews had a special covenant with God. Their security as a people was tied to their faithfulness to the obligations of that covenant.

Hierarchy: Before the destruction of the temple in Jerusalem (70 CE), the high priest and priestly assistants were primary; now rabbis (teachers) are primary leaders. A monarchy existed for only about four hundred years (900s–500s BCE).

Primary Festivals: Weekly: Sabbath. Annual: Rosh Hashanah (New Year), Yom Kippur, Sukkot, Hanukkah, Purim, Pesach (Passover), Shavuot. Main Modern Subgroups: Reform; Conservative (Masorti); Orthodox; Reconstructionist.

Relation to Other Religions: The mother tradition of Western religions. Both Christianity and Islam are heavily influenced by Jewish monotheism and, more selectively, by other aspects of Judaism and the Tanakh.

Ancient Groups

The following groups (except for the Samaritans) arose in the Maccabean period, in the second and early first century BCE. Most were wiped out in the Jewish revolts against Rome, in the first and second centuries CE.

Essenes: Often identified with an apocalyptic sect not content with life under the Maccabees. They formed an isolated ascetic, scribal, and priestly community near the Dead Sea at Qumran. The Dead Sea Scrolls were part of their library.

Maccabees: The nickname of the Hasmoneans, a priestly family who led the revolt against the Seleucid Greeks (167–164 BCE) and liberated Palestine for a few decades before the Roman conquest of the East.

Pharisees: A nonpriestly group whose concern about religious purity and the study of Torah and oral traditions gave them popular influence in the society Their traditions influence rabbinic Judaism.

Sadducees: The religious elite who controlled the Jerusalem temple and its economy. They rejected the oral Torah and some of the newer ideas in Judaism.

Samaritans: A group in central Palestine with obscure Jewish ancestry. They used a version of the Pentateuch and expected a prophet-like messianic figure.

Zealots: A collection of diverse discontents and apocalyptic militants who led

the revolt against Rome.

The Ten Commandments

(Note that Jews and Christians divide the Ten Commandments differently, and within Christianity there are differences in how the commandments are divided.)

1. **I am the LORD your God, who brought you out of the land of Egypt, the house of bondage:**

2. You shall have no other gods beside Me. You shall not make for yourself a sculptured image, or any likeness of what is in the heavens above, or on the earth below, or in the waters under the earth. You shall not bow down to them or serve them. . . .

3. You shall not swear falsely by the name of the LORD your God; for the LORD will not clear one who swears falsely by His name.

4. Remember the sabbath day and keep it holy. Six days you shall labor and do all your work. But the seventh day is a sabbath to the LORD your God; you shall not do any work—you, your son or your daughter, your male or female slave, your livestock, or the

alien resident in your towns. For in six days the LORD made heaven and earth, the sea, and all that is in them, but rested the seventh day; therefore the LORD blessed the sabbath day and consecrated it.

5. Honor your father and your mother, that you may long endure on the land which the LORD your God is giving you.

6. You shall not murder.

7. You shall not commit adultery.

8. You shall not steal.

9. You shall not bear false witness against your neighbor.

10. You shall not covet your neighbor's house: You shall not covet your neighbor's wife, or his male or female slave, or his ox or his ass, or anything that is your neighbor's.

Exodus 20:2–14 (Tanakh: The Holy Scriptures, © Jewish

Publication Society, 1985)

Major Leaders

Biblical Period

Abraham: The father of the Hebrews, who, with his son Isaac, his grandson Jacob (also called Israel), and Jacob's twelve sons are counted as the patriarchs.

Moses: Lawgiver who presented the Torah and covenant to Israel and founded the nation.

David (900s BCE): The idealized king, whose dynasty is featured as one of the key elements in the restoration of Israel.

Medieval Period

Maimonides (1138–1204): A Spanish Jewish philosopher and commentator on the Talmud; formulated thirteen principles of Judaism.

Rashi (1040–1105): French rabbinic commentator on the Bible and the Talmud.

Modern Period

Moses Mendelssohn (1729–86): German philosopher; leader of the Jewish Enlightenment.

Abraham Geiger (1810–74): German rabbi; founder of the Reform movement.

Samson R. Hirsch (1808–88): German rabbi; leader of the Neo-Orthodox movement, which challenged Reform innovations.

Zacharias Frankel (1801–75): German rabbi; founder of the positivis historical school, which influenced Conservative Judaism in North America.

Theodor Herzl (1860–1904): Austrian journalist; founder of World Zionist Organization; sought to create a Jewish state.

Mordecai Kaplan (1881–1983): American rabbi and founder of Reconstructionist Judaism.

Medieval Groups

Karaite: A group of Babylonian Jews, formed in the 700s, who rejected the authority of the Talmud and the rabbinic tradition. They emphasized a more literal approach to Hebrew scripture.

Kabbalist: A general term for a Jewish mystic who sought the hidden meaning behind the external realities and the coded meaning of texts. Kabbalism did much to revitalize Judaism from the 1200s, at a time when European expulsion of Jews was beginning.

Ashkenazi: Jews of German background, including most eastern European Jews. Yiddish was their language, and Christianity dominated the culture under which they took their shape.

Sephardic: Jews largely of Spanish background who migrated to the Ottoman Empire, Italy, and the Netherlands when they were deported from Spain. Ladino was their language, and Islam the dominant culture under which they took their shape.

Modern Groups

Hasidic: A mystical movement founded by Baal Shem Tov (1700–1760) in Poland; particularly important to eastern European Jews. It emphasized devotion and joy of the common Jew over the learning of the rabbis as a means of harmony with God.

Reform: Founded in the 1800s; emphasizes an ethical monotheism rather than ritual, law, and messianic expectations. Such change allowed Jews to identify more easily with Western Enlightenment society. This group views Judaism as always needing a reforming spirit in order to be authentic.

Conservative or Masorti: Founded in the 1800s in reaction to Reform Judaism's radical discarding of tradition; reflects diverse positions between the Reform and Orthodox. Judaism is to be reformed using historical scholarship as the tool to distinguish the nonbinding elements in Jewish practice from the essential ones.

Orthodox: Maintains traditional practices and beliefs. Jewish legislation of the Torah and Talmud is eternal and divinely given and thus not subject to change. Various groups, from liberalizing to rigorously traditional (Haredi), make up Jewish orthodoxy.

Reconstructionist: Founded on the principle of Judaism as an evolving religious culture, subject to change. Views Judaism as a human construct, as Reform Judaism does.

Zionist: Founded by Theodor Herzl; primarily a secular and political movement, whose goal was to establish a Jewish homeland. After the nation of Israel was established, Zionism focused on aiding Jewish immigrants to Israel.

Divine Names

As monotheists, the Jews did not have a pantheon of gods; however, various names were used for their god. In particular, Jews sought ways to avoid pronouncing the name **YHWH**, using various circumlocutions.

YHWH: The Tetragrammaton; often seen with vowels included (Yahweh). It is the personal name of the Hebrew god, which was revealed to Moses. The word Jehovah is an artificial Christian construct based on these consonants, with J used instead of Y (under German influence). The omission of the vowels is intended to protect against pronouncing the name of God. Jews often write the English word God without a vowel (G-d).

Adonai (lit., "Lord"): This word is often pronounced wherever the letters

YHWH occur in the Bible.

Elohim: A generic name for god in Semitic languages; often used for God in the Hebrew scriptures. Its abbreviated form "El" was often used in compounds (e.g., El-Shaddai, "God Almighty").

Ein Sof (lit., "The Unlimited"): The name given to the unknowable and limitless God of kabbalistic speculation.

Ha-Shem (lit., "the Name"): Another common circumlocution for the name of God.

Creed

Jews have no formal creed, although some Jewish scholars have drawn up lists of primary articles of faith. A popular list is Maimonides's "Thirteen Principles" from the 1200s. The most popular form is the hymn Yigdal (lit., "may he be magnified"), found in Jewish prayer books.

Thirteen Principles

1. God exists.

2. There is only one God; there is no other.

3. God does not have physical form, nor is he subject to physical needs.

4. God is eternal—the first and the last.

5. Prayer is to be directed to God alone. No other is worthy of such acts.

6. God communicates with humans through prophets.

7. Moses is the primary prophet.

8. The Torah was given by God to Moses.

9. There will be no other Torah.

10. God observes all deeds and thoughts of humans.

11. God rewards those who keep his commandments and punishes those who violate his commandments.

12. The Messiah will come. One is to wait daily, no matter how long until Messiah comes.

13. The dead will be resurrected, when God pleases.

Sites

Diaspora (lit., "dispersion"): A term used for the areas outside Palestine in which Jews resided. Until modern times, this often meant a resident-alien status for Jews.

Israel: Land and independence were especially cherished by people whose beginnings were those of nomadic strangers. Jews called Israel the "promised land." In 1948, Israel became an independent Jewish nation, giving Jews a homeland for the first time in almost two thousand years.

Mount Sinai: The mountain in the Sinai Desert where, according to tradition, Moses received the Ten Commandments and Yahweh made a covenant with the Israelites.

Synagogue: A community center in which numerous activities take place, the most important of which is the weekly Sabbath service.

Temple: The first, called Solomon's temple, was destroyed by the Babylonians in 586 BCE; the second temple was destroyed by the Romans in 70 CE.

Western Wall (Wailing Wall): The western wall of the Second Temple complex. With the temple destroyed, Jews throughout the centuries came to this location to pray for the restoration of Israel.

Zion: The hill on which the temple was situated; considered the center of the cosmos, God's holy hill. The Islamic Dome of the Rock shrine stands there now.

Prayer

The Eighteen Benedictions (Blessings)—also called Amidah (lit., "standing"), Tephillah (lit., "prayer"), or She-moneh Esrei (lit., "eighteen")—is the principal prayer in the Jewish liturgy, going back two thousand years. It is made up of nineteen blessings, the current twelfth having been added to the original eighteen sometime in the early period. The following is a brief summary of the main features of the blessings and petitions.

1. God's greatness as God of the fathers/patriarchs
2. God's power in a variety of situations
3. God's holiness
4. God's gift of knowledge
5. God's gift of repentance
6. God's gift of pardon and forgiveness from sin
7. God's redemption of Israel from its struggles
8. God's healing of the sick
9. God's blessings of the various produce of the ground
10. God's gathering of the dispersed of Israel
11. God's restoration of righteousness and justice

12. God's punishment of the wicked and heretics
13. God's reward of the pious
14. God's rebuilding of the city of Jerusalem
15. God's restoration of the royal house of David
16. God's acceptance and response to prayers
17. God's restoration of worship at the temple in Jerusalem
18. Extensive thanks and blessings to God
19. God's peace on Israel

Texts of Torah (Law)

(in order of composition)

Torah: The first five books of the Hebrew Bible, the primary source for Torah; also called the Pentateuch (lit., "five" + "tool" or "book").

Tanakh (Tanak): An acronym for the three parts of the Hebrew Bible: Torah (Law) + Neviim (Prophets) + Ketuvim (Writings); commonly called the Hebrew Bible or simply the Bible (= Christian "Old Testament").

Mishnah (lit., "repetition"): The primary collection of oral Torah, complementing the written Torah of the Tanakh; compiled about 200 CE from older traditions.

Talmud (lit., "study"): The Mishnah and commentary on it (called the Gemara) together compose the Talmud. Two versions were compiled: one in Palestine, called the Jerusalem Talmud (300s CE); the other (more influential) in Babylon (400s CE). Medieval commentaries are incorporated into present texts of the Talmud. Those by Rashi (1040–1105) and Maimonides (1135–1204) are particularly influential.

Responsa: Collections of written replies from rabbis to questions about the Torah, after the completion of the Talmud. There are over one thousand volumes of responsa.

Shulchan Aruch (lit., "the prepared table"): Originally a Sephardic work from the 1500s; it was annotated in the same century with Ashkenazi alternative practices. It is the most used guidebook for Torah observance among observant Jews.

Festivals

Rosh Hashanah (lit., "beginning of the year"): Jewish New Year, in September or October; begins a ten-day solemn period of repentance an self-examination, which ends on Yom Kippur. Called the High Holy Days or Days of Awe.

Yom Kippur (lit., "Day of Atonement"): The holiest day of the Jewish calendar, marked by fasting, prayer, and repentance.

Sukkot (lit., "tabernacles" or "booths"): A seven-day harvest festival, linked to the wandering of the Hebrew exiles in the desert after their escape from Egypt.

Pesach (lit., "to pass over"): Commonly known as Passover. Celebrates the exodus, the escape of the ancient Hebrews from Egyptian slavery; a special meal (the seder) with various foods, including unleavened bread (matzah), isthe highlight.

Hanukkah (lit., "dedication"): Also called the "Feast of Lights." Celebrates the purification and rededication of the temple after the Jewish victory over Syrian Greek (Seleucid) overlords. A central feature is a miraculous eigh day supply of holy oil used for light in the temple. A special nine-branch candlestick is used.

Purim (lit., "lots"): Recalls the Queen Esther story, in which Persian Jews were saved when the drawing of lots exposed a plot to kill them. Costumes and boisterous plays are featured.

Shavuot (lit., "weeks"): Commonly known as Pentecost (Greek., lit., "fifty"), celebrated fifty days after Passover; commemorates the giving of Torah.

Sabbath (lit. "rest"): Seventh day of the week, designated for rest and pious reflection; connected to both the creation of the world and the giving of Torah.

Symbols

Kashruth: Jewish dietary laws. Many symbols indicate kosher (clean) foods, depending on which of various Jewish agencies supervised the procedure.

Menorah: A seven-branched candlestick, found in the temple; represents the seven days of creation. It has been the most recognizable symbol of Judaism from ancient times. A special nine-branched menorah is used for Hanukkah.

Mezuzah (lit., "doorpost"): Portions of Torah in a small container attached to the doorposts of a Jewish home.

Star of David (more correctly: Magen [shield] of David): The most common symbol of modern Judaism, featured on the flag of Israel; gained popularity as a symbol for Judaism after Zionism adopted it in 1897.

Tallit: Prayer shawl, with a fringe on each of the four corners.

Tefillin/Phylactery: Small leather boxes containing portions of Torah, bound to the forehead and arm during prayer.

Tetragrammaton/Tetragram (lit., "four letters"): The four consonants (YHWH) in the Hebrew word Yahweh, the personal name of the Jewish God.

Yarmulke/Kippah: A skull cap worn by Jewish men. Orthodox Jews cover their heads in all public places, Conservative Jews (and some Reform) when at prayer.

Rites and Rituals

Circumcision (Bris): As a sign of the covenant, Jewish baby boys have the foreskin of the penis removed in a ceremony when they are eight days old. They are also named at this time. Male converts are required to undergo this procedure. A mohel performs the surgery.

Bar Mitzvah (lit., "son of the commandment"): The ceremony that declares a Jewish boy of age thirteen to be a full member of the community. The event is celebrated in the synagogue, with the boy reading from Torah.

Bat Mitzvah (lit., "daughter of the commandment"): A ceremony for girls, parallel to the bar mitzvah for boys, found in all forms of Judaism except orthodoxy.

Sitting Shivah: A seven-day period of mourning after the death of a close relative. The family restricts its activities, and friends visit. Mourners sit on low stools or on the floor.

The Passover Seder: A highly ritualized meal, in which Jews recall the exodus of the Hebrews from Egyptian slavery. Specific foods are used to illustrate aspects of the story.

Offices

Cantor (from Latin, "singer"): Leader of music and prayer in synagogue services. The duties vary from congregation to congregation. The office was established in the Middle Ages, when more complex music became the fashion.

Cohen: A priest. A few roles continue for the cohen, though the temple where priests were to function has not existed for two thousand years.

Exilarch: Political head of the Jewish community in Babylonia until the thirteenth century.

Gaon (lit., "eminence"): Originally used as a title of respect for the head of Babylonian academies of Torah study; now widely used for a rabbi expert in Torah.

High Priest: An office during the temple period. The high priest was to be a descendent of Aaron, the first high priest.

Levite: An assistant to the priest, with various temple duties. After the destruction of the temple, Levites lost a role in Judaism, although their identity as Levites has been maintained.

Mohel: A person trained in the procedure of circumcision.

Prophet: One who is viewed as speaking for God. The Israelites had both official and unofficial prophets, some who supported the temple and palace and others who challenged it. One section of the Hebrew Bible incorporates the messages of some of these prophets.

Rabbi: A teacher of Torah, and spiritual adviser and leader in the synagogue; primary Jewish leaders after the destruction of the temple.

Terminology

Holocaust (lit., "whole" + "burning"): The attempt by Nazi Germany to exterminate the Jews; also referred to as ha-Shoah (the calamity).

Matrilineal: In Judaism, the view that only those born to a Jewish mother are considered Jewish by birth.

Parve (Pareve) (lit., "neutral"): This word, or an abbreviation P, appears on kosher labeling for products that may be eaten with either meat or dairy dishes.

Yeshiva (lit., "sitting"): The academy for study of Torah leading to ordination as a rabbi.

Yiddish: An English form of the German word jüdisch (Jewish). Yiddish is a dialect of German spoken by Ashkenazi Jews. Most of the vocabulary is German; the script uses the Hebrew alphabet.